The Fourth Sunday of Advent

2 Samuel 7:1-11, 16 * Psalm 89:1-4, 19-26
Romans 16:25-27 * Luke 1:26-38

Prayer

Gracious God,
as we enter this fourth week of Advent, Christmas is near,
and our hearts turn again toward the coming of Jesus.
In the midst of the busyness of these days, slow us down and help us make room for Christ. Prepare not only our homes, but our hearts,
to receive the gift of Your love.
As we gather, open our hearts to Your Word and our ears to Your Spirit.
Deepen our faith, renew our hope, and remind us that You are a God who keeps Your promises. Come, Lord Jesus.
We are waiting for You.
Amen.

Opening

1. What is a time when an unexpected piece of news completely changed the direction of your plans or your year?

2. Looking back at past holiday seasons, what is one gift or surprise that genuinely stands out in your memory?

3. When a sudden change of plans happens, are you the type of person who immediately pivots and adapts, or do you need a few days to process and grieve the old plan?

Engaging the Text

1. What details in the angel Gabriel's description of Jesus (verses 31–33) would have sounded most striking or overwhelming to a young Jewish teenager in Nazareth?

2. Mary experienced sudden confusion, asked an honest question, and then moved to radical surrender (verse 38). Where do you find yourself most often in that progression right now—confusion, questioning, or surrender?

3. What are some "impossible" or daunting circumstances in your life right now where you need to be reminded of Gabriel's words in verse 37, that "no word from God will ever fail" (or "nothing will be impossible with God")?

Application Activity

The "Interrupted Planner" Reflection

This exercise contrasts our need for control with Mary's radical surrender.

The Activity: Take a blank index cards or small piece of paper. Write down one or two big goals, plans, or expectations you have for the upcoming year or the current season.

The Twist: Draw a large, bold "X" over your card/paper, representing Gabriel's interruption of Mary's normal, planned life.

Discussion Prompt: If God were to completely redirect this specific plan for His purposes, what fears surface? What would it take for you to say, "May your word to me be fulfilled"?